

DHA renamed Office for Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA)

BULLETIN

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Press Release

The United Nations Secretary-General has approved a new structure to replace the United Nations Department of Humanitarian Affairs (DHA). On November 14, Secretary-General Kofi Annan announced the appointment of Sergio Vieira de Mello as Emergency Relief Coordinator, at the level of Under-Secretary-General, effective January 1998.

Acting a call from the Secretary-General for a reorientation of the Department's work, the new head of that Department, Sergio de Mello, provided details of the new structure, which will be renamed the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA).

According to a United Nations Spokesman, Mr. de Mello has identified three co-functions for the new entity: coordination of humanitarian emergency response; policy development; and advocacy on humanitarian issues.

Martin Griffiths has been named Deputy to the Under Secretary General and Deputy Emergency Relief Coordinator.

The staff members in the new structure will decrease from 360 to 137 through a redistribution of responsibilities to other agencies or units in the Secretariat. Roughly half of the new staff will be in New York, with the remainder in Geneva.